

Philosophy and Theology.

A Historical-Critical Treatise

by

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cand. theol.

Copenhagen.

Bog- og Papiirhandler C. W. Stinck's Forlag.

Thieles Bogtrykkeri.

1866.

[3] When a debate concerning an essential point of contention returns again and again, when the discussion is taken up anew again and again, then it may seem trivial, to an outward view, always to be quarreling in this way about the same thing. But it will also be so only for the outward, superficial view. In reality the discussion must always return to the same field of battle with richer equipment, furnished with the new means that the advancing development has brought forth since the last time. This finds its application when one considers the different conditions and presuppositions under which the disputes between philosophy and theology have been conducted at different times, and particularly when we look to the peculiar way in which the dispute has developed in *our* literature.

Whenever, therefore, the matter is stirred up anew, it is natural to turn one's gaze back to the earlier history of the matter, in order to see whether the new contribution has really understood it and made right use of it — for that is the first condition for getting any further. But here things may then turn out so strangely that the dispute is really no longer conducted to settle the matter itself, but to settle who actually *has* won in the decisive dispute. For in a dispute of ideas things do not go as in the battles of the bodily world, where the decision is something one can take hold of and touch.

[4] When I read the new contribution¹⁾ to the dispute mentioned above, which, from what I have heard, is regarded by many as having no small significance, particularly as an attack on the view of the relation between theology and philosophy, and between faith and knowledge, maintained by Prof. R. Nielsen, I got an example of this. Although the author seems to regret that “since the dispute that was conducted in its time over Martensen's Dogmatics, all polemic about the relation of faith and knowledge to each other has fallen completely silent”, he has nevertheless not done what was in his power to carry the matter further in the right way: namely, to give himself a clear account of how matters stand. This has harmed his work all the more, as the historical course of development points fairly clearly toward the view that must be the result of the long, entangled dispute. A historical presentation of this course of development will be able at once to show us which the victorious view must be, and to furnish a critique of the work named.

Every student, and particularly one who has sat on the pupils' bench in the philosophical as well as in the theological lecture hall, must feel called upon to make clear

¹⁾“Samvittighed og Videnskab”, by A. C. Larsen, *cand. theol.*

to himself what it really is that is disputed here, and how he himself must take his stand in this matter. This is by no means easy for the young man, who must essentially take the part of a learner; for here authority stands against authority, and he who now perhaps sees shaken what he took to stand fast as a rock easily becomes disheartened and wavering. But precisely by this he is then prevented from one thing: what the Latins call *jurare in verba magistri* — he cannot, after all, swear by two authorities at once! So he then sees the necessity of taking his side according to his own best conviction.

What now leads me to come forward publicly with my view of the matter, instead of [5] keeping it to myself, is that it seems fitting to me that the dispute should also be fought out among the younger men, after the main battle was fought in its time by the masters themselves.

In this respect I have, to be sure, a predecessor in the author of the work cited above, which has given me occasion for this little treatise.

Before I proceed to my real task: to show how the view that in my conviction is the [6] only tenable one emerges from the whole course of the dispute, especially by reason of the turn this has taken in our literature through S. Kierkegaard's appearance, — I shall briefly indicate why I must regard Mr. Larsen's contribution as misconceived.

The author of "Samvittighed og Videnskab" naturally acknowledges a difference between faith and knowledge; but he will not concede that they are absolutely heterogeneous. He regards it as impossible to hold fast the conviction of the reality of modern knowledge and the assurance of the reality of Christianity, except by the help of scientific theology, where faith and knowledge can negotiate with each other (p. 60).

But in this way he only reconciles the two opposites by confounding them. He makes science religious in order to be able to make religion scientific.

When I say that the author makes science religious, I mean by this that he refers problems that belong to philosophy to religion. — Whence do we know that external sense perception has reality? This question, in the author's opinion, cannot be decided "by way of *knowledge*". The external world comes to be real for me only through *faith* (p. 13–14), and this faith is in principle one with that in which God exists for me (p. 14). This is an equivocation. Philosophy is really able "by way of knowledge" to solve the problem of objectification¹⁾. And insofar as one can speak of a philosophical *sapere aude*, a faith in [7] the reality of thought, then this faith is in principle different from the religious one, even

¹⁾Reference may be made here to "Grundideernes Logik" I, p. 172–177.

if it can be supported by it. This can be seen from the relation between dogmatic and critical philosophy: “die kritische Philosophie begreift, was die dogmatische geglaubt hatte”¹⁾, and what dogmatic philosophy had believed in was precisely the reality of cognition. — What is the relation between spirit and nature? About this, in the author’s opinion, one can learn nothing in science: “for natural science as such has no concept of nature; as such it knows nothing of nature’s relation to the Absolute. The powers between which the struggle is waged, without reconciliation ever being possible, are pantheism and Christianity” (p. 38). This is simply incorrect. For it is overlooked that there is something called philosophy of nature: here one has a concept of nature, even if physics otherwise has none; and here the relation between idea and nature is shown. Here one can learn how the highest cause works in and through all the finite causes. The philosophy of nature will neither believe nor comprehend the dogma of creation; but it will comprehend the relation between spirit and nature as a fundamental relation. If one wants to call this pantheism, that is an equivocal expression; for the philosophy of nature is not religion but a scientific grounding of the phenomena of nature.

If the author thus²⁾ overlooks philosophy, he is all the better friends with physics. What an *entente cordiale* there is for him between “the real laws of nature” on the one side and the dogma of creation and the miracles on the other side! For the dogma of creation implies that nature is a real “something”: so there are also “real laws” and a [8] “real natural science” (p. 33)! But what, I wonder, will natural science say when one lets the dogma speak its piece: “it is something — and yet nothing for the Almighty!” I do not believe it helps to explain to the natural scientist that now we pass over into another science, where one has this “other way of seeing things”. — And now the miracle! Yes, says the author, it “precisely confirms the law of nature; if one posits the exception, one must also posit the rule” (p. 37). A splendid piece of reasoning — especially for thieves and robbers, who can thus earn themselves merit by enforcing the validity of the law, if in a rather “indirect” way!

The author is right that it is not Christianity and natural science “that one must choose between”; but he has no right to put “theology” in place of “Christianity” (which he does p. 37–38); for this changes the whole matter. For the dispute between theology and natural science is a dispute between two sciences.

But it is not so strange after all that the author — consciously or unconsciously — identifies Christianity and theology. For he has only made science religious in order to

¹⁾Kuno Fischer, *Geschichte der neuern Philosophie I*, p. 241.

²⁾One cannot help thinking here of Hegel’s words: “Sie ignoriren die Philosophie, aber nur um in ihren willkürlichen Raisonnements nicht genirt zu werden”. *Geschichte der Philosophie I*, p. 80.

make religion scientific.

When the author wants to make religion an object of science, it is by no means his opinion that one can “just like that, without further ado” comprehend the religious truths. But he thinks that “it is something quite different when I, after having gone out beyond myself in faith and after having posited God as cause, then afterwards infer back from my God-consciousness, as effect, to the constitution of God’s being” (p. 20). By all this going out and in one then attains “a science that essentially wants to be nothing other than the religious life’s own clear and transparent consciousness of itself” (p. 54).

But, one must ask, does proving and grounding then go more easily after one has become a believer than before? Let it be well noted that the question is not: whether the religious consciousness is convinced of the truth of that in which it believes, but: [9] whether this conviction can become a scientific insight and comprehension?

Now Johannes Climacus says that the Christian truth is the paradox! This hindrance to “the religious life’s clear and transparent consciousness of itself” must then first be cleared out of the way. And that goes easily enough: “It is one thing to express oneself with lyrical-passionate energy in a polemical situation; it is something quite different to speak positively-scientifically” (p. 49).

No one, surely, disagrees with the author in this; but when he concludes from it that Joh. Climacus’s proposition can hold only when it is the humorist who has it in his mouth “in a polemical situation”, then this is¹⁾ a strange mixture of thoughtlessness and sophistry. The believer’s relation to the object of faith in faith and hope is a direct relation, in which there is no paradox; but as soon as the believer wants to have objective (i.e. scientific)²⁾ certainty, then the object of faith shows itself — according to Joh. Climacus — as the absurd. But, says the author, Joh. Climacus himself says, after all, that “objective indifference” gets to know nothing at all about Christianity; how then can one get to know objectively that it is the absurd? The answer is not so difficult after all: for getting to know that it is the absurd, and getting to *know*³⁾ nothing at all, are one and the same. The paradox must, before the scientific tribunal, be declared a *non-ens*. — Nonetheless the author regards Joh. Climacus as happily and well placed in “a place of his own” outside the “positive-scientific”. It is only, as it were, for good measure that the poor humorist must hear that he does not have “positive-scientific” seriousness enough to [10] distinguish between θεός and ὁ θεός (p. 53); and then at the end he receives the lesson

¹⁾How, I wonder, has the author understood the essence and significance of “indirect communication”, when he can conclude in this way!

²⁾What right has the author to define objective certainty as “pure logical certainty of state?”

³⁾Scientifically, of course. — Examples in Joh. Climacus p. 160 f. 166 f.

that one must after all have the objective along too. And from the fact that faith cannot do without “the objective” it is then concluded¹⁾ quite directly: that neither can it do without “scientificity” (p. 54)!

But enough: the author has finished with Johannes Climacus; he now establishes dogma as a fact for the religious consciousness, and engages the understanding (by the author’s own declaration, p. 52, the same²⁾ understanding that the believer had before he became a believer) to set to work (p. 50–52; 71–74). But here one must regret that the author has overlooked precisely what matters. He simply sets religion alongside nature, without thinking of the essential difference between the two, regarded as objects of science³⁾. Of the religious fact holds what Feuerbach says: “Thatsache ist kein Grund”. In the facts of nature, on the other hand, reason can find its own essence and so ground them. “Die Vernunft ist die Hebamme der Natur”. And as it goes with the category “fact”, so it goes with the related category “presupposition”. A scientific presupposition must be able wholly and fully to pass through the fire-test of doubt; this holds also for what [11] is the object of “the immediate sense impressions”: it is not recognized scientifically unless it can be grounded. But the author cannot go along with that: “however justified one may be in demanding doubt, one thing one must nevertheless not demand, that the religious consciousness should doubt the reality of its immediate being” (p. 58.). Yes indeed, that one may and must demand, if science is to come of it, and in this respect theology diverges very greatly in its “demands” from natural science.

We get a practical test of the author’s science in his 3rd treatise, where he wants to show us how God stands “in real reciprocal relation” with time (p. 46). Can he now really develop this reciprocal relation between the eternal, personal, omniscient God and temporal, successive development, so that it becomes a scientific concept? He seems, however, only to show that it “must be thought” — but he does not think it. —

When the author has thus given neither science nor faith what is due to each of them, the reconciliation cannot be lasting either. And that this is so we know not merely *a priori*, but — as what follows shows — also *a posteriori*.

¹⁾In the same cunning way the author earlier put the word “theology” in place of the word “Christianity”.

²⁾This, incidentally, does not matter, since by “understanding” the author understands something altogether formal (p. 50–51). An understanding so “reduced” can be made into anything whatever. The author seems not to know that there is something called philosophical thinking, concept, cognition of ideas. He really makes the task far too easy for himself!

³⁾This is all the less excusable, since this parallel has been contested in a separate treatise: “Er Religionsforskerens Forhold til den saakaldte Aabenbaring det samme som Naturforskerens til Naturen?” By Mag. Stilling. 1853.

In the Middle Ages theology, as scholasticism, was the dominant, indeed the only ^[12] science. "Dogma is true (for the Church teaches it!); therefore it also accords with reason; therefore it can be proved." So one reasoned, and then summoned all the powers of the understanding to build up the great scholastic systems, which have aptly been compared with the Gothic cathedrals. And it was a pious work; just as the pious master builders on the Rhine raised spires pointing toward heaven, where often, high up, where no human eye ever reached, ornaments were placed to the glory of God, so too the scholastic systems, with their whole apparatus of syllogisms and distinctions, were erected *in gloriam Dei*. The scholastics fought with refractory thoughts in the same way as the crusaders against the Saracens, and it went ill with both if they did not bow before faith and the Church.

With the medieval Church scholasticism also fell. Its fall was brought about both by inner self-dissolution and by attack from without. The presupposition of scholasticism was the unity of faith and knowledge: but now Duns Scotus, by making the will the highest principle in opposition to Thomas Aquinas, had already distinguished between the theoretical and the practical, and William Durandus (in the first half of the 14th century) had recognized that there were dogmas which could not and should not be proved, but believed as revealed truths. The presupposition of scholasticism was, further, the unity of thinking and being: but now, through William of Occam, nominalism ^[13] (*universalia sunt nomina, flatus vocis*) had become dominant in a sharpened and renewed form. The attacks from without came partly from the side of thought, now set free, which wanted to tear down the prison in which it had so long been tortured, and partly from the existential, religious standpoint, when Luther broke with the traditional dogma and all the »*traditiones humanæ*« in which it had cocooned itself.

But the new philosophical inquiry did not yet dare to attack the doctrine of the Church itself. In order, then, to be able to maintain the results of their own cognition unchallenged by the authority of the Church, the philosophers set up the separation between *duæ veritates, philosophica et theologica*, by the proposition that something could be true in theology, from the standpoint of dogma, and yet false, or at least unprovable, from the standpoint of philosophy, of reason. As men who asserted this separation may be named Pietro Pomponazzo (at the end of the 15th and the beginning of the 16th century), who concerned himself especially with the doctrine of immortality, and Vanini (at the end of the 16th and the beginning of the 17th century), whom the distinction in question did not save from the stake.

That this distinction was sophistical and untenable is easy to see. For dogma, as

the Church laid it before its faithful for obedient acceptance, was not the evangelical truth with its practical-religious character, but was a theologumenon with ecclesiastical sanction. "Scientific and religious cognition had at that time grown together so ecclesiastically that they could not be separated. When the philosophers, then, in order to preserve the scientific character of their work, declared that in all matters of faith they were willing to submit to the authority of the Church, the Church was certainly justified in calling the sincerity of such a concession into doubt: how could anyone hold fast to a [14] truth of reason and yet acknowledge a theological truth, when the two stand in decisive conflict with each other, and yet both were to count as scientific?"¹⁾

That on these terms the conflict could not lead to reconciliation is then evident. It was continued, accordingly, in the Protestant as well as in the Catholic Church. Beside philosophy there now stood natural science, which has a continuous history only from the 16th century on.

If at the end of the last century the question had been raised who had won in the conflict, theology or philosophy, the answer could hardly have been in doubt. For theology, under the influence of the spirit of the age, had let one miracle fall after another, in the world of spirit as in that of nature. The theology of the philosophical, naturalistic 18th century was no longer any theology at all.

But the general spiritual upsurge at the beginning of this century showed itself in the field of theology as well. It was above all philosophy that now became of importance. Rationalism had been rejected and the principle of faith once more embraced; but in the newer philosophy one saw a possibility of reconciling this principle of faith with the principle of knowledge. Now, then, there came a time of flowering for theology, which, for those who cultivated it, was full of enthusiasm. "Never had so many from the so-called 'better classes' been seen to choose this study as in that²⁾ period.... Just as some years earlier the flower of German youth had placed itself under the banners of war to save the fatherland from political servitude, so in the years of peace that followed those most richly gifted in spiritual respects regarded it as the highest honor and the highest gain to be allowed to serve the Church and to offer it their best powers.... One knew that the struggle was for a noble goal; one believed in the possibility of a final victory, in [15] the possibility of a reconciliation of faith and knowledge, even if one did not see it fully accomplished;... one did not yet regard it as bearing a foreign yoke when theology went hand in hand with philosophy¹⁾."

¹⁾R. Nielsen: *Grundideernes Logik* p. XXII.

²⁾The reference is to the years 1824–33 in Germany.

¹⁾Hagenbach: "Om Aftagelsen af det theol. Studium", in *Clausens Tidsskrift for udenl. theol. Litt.* 1858,

It was above all the Hegelian philosophy that was rich in promises of a reconciliation of faith and knowledge. Its content was the Absolute — but the content of Christianity, too, is surely the absolute truth²⁾. It possessed besides, in its dialectical method, the capacity to carry through the mediation between the contending principles. How rich, then, were the presuppositions here for a speculative theology!

But did Hegel, then, make no distinction at all between faith and knowledge? Yes, he did, but an ambiguous one, which was therefore afterwards interpreted *in utramque partem*. “Worauf es ganz allein ankommt, ist der Unterschied der Formen des spekulativen Denkens von den Formen der Vorstellung und des reflectirenden Verstandes”³⁾. This was now understood in two ways. Some said: “Representation is a lower, consequently an inadequate, and so a relatively untrue form, which must therefore be dissolved by thought.” But others held that one could well keep the Hegelian determination of faith as an immediate knowledge, “only that we do not then understand by the immediate the lower, the imperfect, which is to be abolished by philosophy as the perfect, but the original, the primitive knowledge, which is the foundation of speculation⁴⁾.”

This latter view then became the basis of a new tendency in theological dogmatics, which also found representatives at our university. It was above all the present Bishop Dr. Martensen who, by his¹⁾ dissertation for the licentiate degree, paved the way in [16] this country for this “new era.” He would by no means grant philosophy primacy over theology, but would instead assert a principle of its own for theological speculation; while philosophical thinking is autonomous, theological thinking is theonomous (*dogma de deo, auctore conscientiae sui humanae, verum esse theoriae cognitionis fundamentum, quo efficitur nexus necessarius inter scientiam theologiam et auctoritatem dogmatis, vinculum indissolubile scientiae et conscientiae*²⁾). The concept of mediation was retained, but it was demanded that “mediation should be sought from the standpoint of believing cognition”³⁾.

Here, then, a dogmatic principle had been laid down which could supposedly maintain the scientific character of theology by uniting in itself the principle of faith with that of

p. 13, 21.

²⁾It is said of the religious spirit that its content is “als religiös wesentlich spekulativ”, and of the content of philosophy that it is “spekulativ und damit religiös”. Hegel, *Encyclopädie der philos. Wissenschaften*. Berlin 1845. p. 513.

³⁾Op. cit. p. 512.

⁴⁾Martensen, *Christian Dogmatics*. 1849. p. 13.

¹⁾*De Autonomia conscientiae sui humanae in theologiam dogmaticam nostri temporis introducta*. Hauniae 1837.

²⁾Op. cit. p. 135.

³⁾*Dogmatiske Oplysninger*, by H. Martensen. 1850. pag. 66–69. — “The center of Christianity, the doctrine of the Incarnation, shows precisely that Christian metaphysics cannot rest in an Either—Or”, as does “the metaphysics of the Jewish religion.” *Tidsskrift for Litteratur og Kritik* 1839, p. 458.

knowledge. But what our literature saw, even in the first years, of productions in this direction was only isolated⁴⁾ attempts, not any thoroughgoing scientific presentation of the doctrine of faith according to the stated principle. “The system was not yet finished” — but it was expected, and all looked forward with great hopes to the further development of the “new era.”

Before we continue the historical account further, we must first call to mind the tendency which — likewise springing from the Hegelian philosophy — went the opposite [17] way from the “believing” speculation. It is Strauß and Feuerbach who are the chief men here. If the answer that knowledge gave, when its testimony was demanded after it had been set face to face with revelation, was for the former tendency unconditionally affirmative, here it became just as unconditionally negative. Negative criticism thus sets itself against positive dogmatics, *contra* against *pro*.

The opposition, then, is here as strong as possible. But should there not after all be something common to the two contending parties, something on which, in spite of all disagreement, they are agreed?

What both parties were agreed on was that the conflict was to be fought out on the ground of science and with the weapons of science. This had been stated from the very outset. When Strauß’s “Leben Jesu” had appeared, the Prussian Ministry of Education asked the famous Neander for a statement on whether it would be right to issue a ban on this book, which was causing so great a stir. In this statement it says: “It is the calling of the theological teachers to work toward this, that the book, which has issued from a tendency opposed to the spirit of the Christian Church, may come to contribute to the advancement of science and thereby to promote the Church’s own interest as well. But this goal can be reached only if this struggle is waged with the weapons of science alone”¹⁾.

But then does the spectacle from the end of the Middle Ages not seem to repeat itself? Here are »*duæ veritates*« — and both, after all, claim to be scientific.

On closer consideration, however, this proves not to be so. We shall here only ask provisionally: what is it that Strauß and Feuerbach attack, religion or theology, — and what does it mean when they declare that they stand on the standpoint of science? — [18] The first question is soon answered: Strauß, besides “Leben Jesu”, in which he dissolves the evangelical history into myths, has of course also written a “Dogmatik”, in which

⁴⁾Here may be named, e.g., “Mester Ekkardt”, the excellent “Bidrag til at oplyse Middelalderens Mystik,” by Dr. Martensen (1840).

¹⁾Luther, on the other hand, on a similar occasion asked the Saxon princes to insist “daß alleine mit dem Worte Gottes in diesen Sachen gehandelt werde, wie den Christen gebühret.”

the dogmatic propositions are dissolved one after another into nothing; and Feuerbach does distinguish between religion and theology as between the immediate, involuntary intuition and conscious reflection, but he turns his weapons against both. What is combated, then, is not merely a truth that claims to be scientific; it is religious truth, the truth of life itself, that is combated here. And as regards the second point, negative criticism holds fast to the fixed and unshakable laws in the world of spirit and of nature, as these prove themselves to human consciousness through science. What rational science cannot check and ground is for this standpoint a *non-ens*.

As surely as religion is one thing and theology another, so surely must the Strauß-Feuerbach criticism be viewed from a double point of view. Over against theology it becomes a conflict between knowledge and knowledge; over against religion it becomes a conflict between knowledge and faith.

“The conflict with Strauß is transformed at once into a conflict between religion and science. It is the critics’ merit to have given the matter so strong a push that precisely thereby it has been driven to this decisive turning point. The conflict of the faith of the Gospel with the Straußian criticism is a conflict of competence, a conflict of sovereignty, a conflict over the supreme power, the highest authority in the world of spirits”¹⁾.

One sees, then, how matters stood. On the one side stood dogmatics with the declaration that knowledge agreed with faith, on the other side criticism with the equally categorical declaration that knowledge conflicted with and consequently dissolved faith. It really seemed to be high time that attention should be directed to the “conflict of [19] competence” between faith and knowledge; for on this — and in this dogmatics and criticism¹⁾ were equally dogmatic — one got the requisite enlightenment from neither of the contending parties.

At this point we now turn to the Kierkegaardian writings. If anywhere, then in these writings everything is summoned to establish and maintain the concept of faith in its distinctiveness.

We shall here consider Kierkegaard only from the point of view just stated. His great importance of course holds for the whole age, and his appearance was indeed determined by the spiritual condition of the time as a whole. He is a rare example of how a gift and a genius such as falls to the lot of only few human beings can be exclusively taken possession of (as it were, taken captive) by the ethical-religious aim: himself existing in the truth, to be for others a teacher in existing in the truth. But what is peculiar to him lies in his method — his maieutics, to recall Socrates. He saw his contemporaries as

¹⁾“Evangelietroen og Theologien”. Tolv Forelæsninger, by R. Nielsen. 1850. pag. 85.

¹⁾Cf. Martensen’s Dogmatics § 17, Remark.

caught in an enormous illusion of the senses, namely this, that “we are all Christians”; an illusion of the senses can never be removed directly — hence “indirect communication”! If the sickness rests on taking the phenomenon for the essence, then the remedy must consist in setting discord between essence and phenomenon, so that the deception may cease and the essence be recognized as essence.

It has often been objected to this indirect communication that it was too “artificial”, too reflective: “Christianity, religion in general, is surely conditioned precisely by the immediate relation to the divine!” To this Kierkegaard replies: one is mistaken in thinking that it is the remedy that introduces reflection; no, reflection — that is precisely the [20] misfortune — is there beforehand, but only as half-reflection, false reflection. “The situation is Christendom, which is a determination of reflection. In Christendom — to become a Christian is either to become what one is (the inwardness of reflection, or the reflection of inward deepening), or it is first to be torn out of a delusion, which again is a determination of reflection”¹⁾.

On this, then, rests the explanation of “the ambiguity or duplexity in the whole authorship, whether the author is an aesthetic or a religious author”. In this connection it is now neither the aesthetic nor the religious writings to which we would chiefly refer, but what Kierkegaard himself has designated as “the turning point in the whole authorship”: “Unscientific Postscript”, by Johannes Climacus.

But what we must no doubt settle first is whether Johannes Climacus really means what he says. “He is a humorist, after all, playing and toying with everything in the most frivolous way!” Let us hear, then, how he himself conceived his task when he resolved to become an author. “Out of love for men, out of despair over my embarrassing position of having accomplished nothing and of being able to make nothing easier than it has been made, out of genuine interest in those who make everything easy, I then conceived it as my task: everywhere to create difficulties.” “If I now dared proclaim loudly that I had come into the world for, and been called to, counteracting speculation, that this was my judging work, while my prophetic work was to foretell a matchless future, as to which men, because I was loud-voiced and called, could safely rely on what I said — then there would no doubt be many a one who, failing to regard the whole thing as a fantastical [21] reminiscence in a fool’s head, would take it in earnest”²⁾. Earnestness is not something one can take hold of and touch in that way. Earnestness is the essential relation to the essential, but not directly commensurable with its expression. On the contrary:

¹⁾“The Point of View for My Work as an Author”, pag. 33.

²⁾How he then came to “a closer understanding of his own notion, that he must try to do something difficult”, must be read in his own words (p. 174 ff.).

earnestness is inwardness, and “the form of opposition is precisely the dynamometer of inwardness.”

For Johannes Climacus, the error of speculation lay in the whole tendency of the age: “that, on account of so much knowledge, people had altogether forgotten what it is to exist and what inwardness signifies.” Therefore he wanted to “make difficulties” — by laying stress on existence. When the existing human being asks: “What is truth?” what must be meant is the essential truth, the truth of life, “the truth that essentially¹⁾ relates itself to existence.” Truth in general is the agreement, the unity, of subjectivity and objectivity; it thus contains, even viewed purely abstractly, a doubling. But this doubling returns with intensified emphasis when it is not *in abstracto* but existentially that the question of truth is asked. Here the two-sidedness becomes a disjunction. The two ways of cognition go in opposite directions: the one turns toward the objective and leads — precisely in order to bring out the objective as objectively as possible — away from the subjective; the other leads to subjectivity, to the appropriation of the truth in inwardness.

The thesis of the subjective, existing thinker then becomes: subjectivity is the truth. There is a difference of sphere between scientific and existential truth. Here no mediation is possible; for by the subject-object of mediation one comes back to abstraction, whereas the question was precisely “how an existing subject *in concreto* relates itself to the truth.”

“But,” — it is said — “it is surely highly one-sided to say that subjectivity is the truth; [22] subjectivity must, after all, have taken up the objective into itself in order to be the truth.” This objection rests partly on an “imperfect and undialectical distinction” between subjective and objective; partly it has not rightly understood the thesis stated. Let us hear Johannes Climacus. “While objective thinking is indifferent to the thinking subject and his existence, the subjective thinker, as existing, is essentially interested in his own thinking, is existing in it. Therefore his thinking has another kind of reflection, namely that of inwardness, of possession, by which it belongs to the subject and to no one else . . . The reflection of inwardness is the subjective thinker’s double reflection”¹⁾. There is thus not merely a relation of reflection between the objective and thinking, but also between the thought objective and the thinker’s existence. But this latter reflection is not logical but practical; it is a *salto mortale*, to recall Jakobi, a “dialectical deed and act”²⁾.

What has been developed so far states the conditions for every existing person’s

¹⁾*Only ethical and ethical-religious cognition is therefore essential cognition. But all ethical and all ethical-religious cognition is essentially related to the fact that the one who cognizes exists.” Unscientific Postscript p. 145.

¹⁾Unscientific Postscript. p. 50–51.

²⁾Stilling: “Om den indbildte Forsoning af Tro og — Viden”. 1850. p. 30–32.

relation to the truth: it is “the Socratic wisdom, whose immortal merit is precisely to have heeded the essential significance of the fact that the one who cognizes is existing, for which reason he, in his ignorance, was in the truth in the highest sense within paganism”³⁾.

If, then, there is to be a standpoint essentially different from the Socratic, this difference must rest on the closer determination of the truth.

The proposition “Subjectivity is the truth” contains an opposition to objectivity. This opposition must then also find its expression in the determination of the truth.
 [23] While objective thinking seeks certainty in objective grounds, the truth, seen from the subjective standpoint, that of existence, is objective uncertainty. The grounds that can be in question here are merely subjective, existential.

“When subjectivity, inwardness, is the truth, then the truth, objectively determined, is the paradox; and the fact that the truth is objectively the paradox shows precisely that subjectivity is the truth”¹⁾.

The paradox is present where the eternal and unconditioned confronts the temporal and conditioned. For Socrates, too, there was a paradox. “Yet the eternal essential truth is itself by no means the paradox, but is so by relating itself to an existing person”. For that the infinite relates itself to the finite is, to be sure, a contradiction from the standpoint of existence, one that is overcome only by a *salto mortale*; but from the standpoint of science, of comprehension, this contradiction is mediated²⁾.

But if the eternal truth and existing in temporality are now put together in the truth itself, then the truth itself becomes paradoxical — and then we have the paradox $\kappa\alpha\tau'$ $\epsilon\tilde{\xi}\sigma\chi\eta\nu$, without mediation being possible.

Here, then, we stand at revelation. The eternal, personal God speaks to man in time: “And God tempted Abraham, and said: Abraham, Abraham, where art thou? but Abraham answered: here am I” (Gen. 22, 1). God himself is born and lives and dies as a human being in time: “The Word was with God, and the Word was God. And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us” (John 1, 1. 14). Here all historical and speculative
 [24] knowledge is of no help; the highest that, along the objective way, can be reached is an approximation, hence no qualitative decision, which comes only through faith. “Instead of the objective uncertainty (on the Socratic standpoint), there is here the certainty that, viewed objectively, it is the absurd, and this absurd, held fast in the passion of

³⁾Unscientific Postscript. p. 150.

¹⁾Op. cit. p. 151.

²⁾Not by a leap but by a transition corresponding to the peculiar character of the functions must comprehending subjectivity in each case move from the finite to the infinite”. Grundideernes Logik p. 230.

inwardness¹⁾ is faith.”

Johannes Climacus has thus set up here a principle of faith that is incompatible with knowledge. And it is not only at the outset, when subjectivity chooses faith, that faith repels and is repelled by knowledge; what holds in principle for the development at its beginning must also hold in its further course.

This principle of his Johannes Climacus now sets against the two tendencies indicated earlier. Against Strauß and Feuerbach he maintains that science lacks competence to judge in the domain of existence; against the scientific doctrine of religion, that the bright shield of faith must not be stained with any spot of objective knowledge. That his polemic was directed chiefly against the latter was due in part, no doubt, to its being the prevailing one in this country, where negative criticism had no original representatives; but it was principally because, in his opinion, it mixed together modern culture and Christianity in an unclear and ambiguous way – in this agreeing with the tendency of the time as a whole.

Here, then, we have the spectacle of three adversaries who make war on one another. If there could perhaps be talk of an alliance between two of them against the third, it would nonetheless obviously be only short-lived.

Attention naturally turns to the party that might perhaps seem to unite the other two in a “higher unity”: dogmatics, which did, after all, maintain *both* faith *and* knowledge. It is clear that the presuppositions were now present for a richer and deeper development [25] of this science: on the one side, after all, the subjective principle of faith, on the other the objective principle of knowledge, had been carried through as sharply and consistently as can be conceived. Here was a victory to be won for whoever could master these opposites.

Then, in the year 1849, Martensen’s “Christian Dogmatics” appeared: “a scientific presentation and grounding of the Christian doctrines of faith in their inner coherence” (§ 1).

For anyone who remembered what demands the author himself had earlier made of a scientific dogmatics – how, on the occasion of the “Either-Or” between supernaturalism and rationalism set up by Mynster, he had upheld mediation and declared¹⁾ that a return to the Christian truth of revelation, except as a “necessary turn lying within the philosophy of our time itself”, produced by carrying through Hegel’s dialectical method, was unscientific (or at any rate “no scientific advance”) – for such a one there

¹⁾“Passion is precisely the tension in the contradiction; when this is taken away, the contradiction is a pleasantry, a bon mot”. Unsc. Postscr. p. 294.

¹⁾See “Tidsskrift for Litteratur og Kritik” 1839, especially p. 464, 469.

was every reason to examine the new “Christian Dogmatics” with particular regard to its scientific principle. Had that program been held fast, and had there even merely been an attempt at carrying it out, then things would have begun to look serious for negative criticism: it had, after all, been promised that in the “immanent cognition of Christology” the Straußian Christology too would be taken up as a “relative mode of conception”, a “sublated ideality”.

For anyone who had seen with how much steadfastness and persistence a whole series of pseudonymous authors, whose aim was to uphold existential truth and faith as its highest, paradoxical form, had hurled one challenge after another at “the System”, which was, to be sure, not yet “finished”, but was nonetheless expected soon to become [26] so — for such a one there was every reason to test how the new “Christian Dogmatics” managed to reconcile the paradox with science, existential with scientific cognition.

“The question,” it runs in the first of the authors who came forward against Martensen’s dogmatics¹⁾, “around which theology and philosophy at the present time must be said to move, as around the true and proper question of principle, can be briefly stated in these words: Will the truth of Christianity by its nature be an object of objective knowledge?.. As a question of principle it can in no way be held off in evasive indeterminacy, but must be answered unconditionally, with Yes or No.” The author then sets side by side the two different answers that the pseudonym Johannes Climacus and the author of the “Christian Dogmatics” give: the one with “an unconditionally decisive No”, the other — “though, to be sure, with some uncertainty” — with Yes. The critique is then directed against this latter answer, in order to show that “the ‘Christian Dogmatics’ has undialectically circumvented the Christian problem”, whereas the pseudonym sharpens it. It is shown first that Martensen has not succeeded in separating *dogmatics* and *philosophy of religion*, “theological” and “philosophical speculation”, but that on the contrary he contradicts himself (cf. § 2 of the Dogmatics with § 8, note). In order now to shed closer light on this unclarity, attention is turned to “the problem of speculation”; it is asked whether the “Christian Dogmatics” acknowledges “*the demands that objective thinking imposes on the one who speculates*”, which are chiefly: “a direct relation between theoretical certainty and speculative insight”, and, as regards method, “the dialectical relation between the presupposition and the abstraction”. These demands would require [27] that all dogmas be transformed into problems²⁾. But that is something the “Christian

¹⁾Mag. S. Kierkegaards ‘Johannes Climacus’ og Dr. H. Martensens ‘Christelige Dogmatik’. En undersøgende Anmeldelse af R. Nielsen”. 1849.

²⁾Cf. “Tidsskrift for Litteratur og Kritik” 1839, p. 464, where the author of the Dogmatics declared that “science could not fully be reconciled with any dogma before it was seen in its dialectical necessity in the System”.

Dogmatics” cannot engage in: the absolute truth of Christianity is unshakable for it: it *believes* in it. Therefore, in the third place, the critic turns his attention to “the problem of faith”, and in particular to *the relation between faith and its object*. According to the Dogmatics this relation is a double one: an existential and a theoretical relation. Very well — says the critic — then set up the objective *object of faith*, baptism and the Lord’s Supper e.g., and let us — in faith — obtain a scientific-objective decision as to what is the true doctrine of baptism or of the Supper! But see: the scientific theory depends on whether it is a *theologia regenitorum* or *irregenitorum* (rationalists), and, as regards the former, again on whether the regenerate person is a Lutheran (and here again: orthodox or pietist, “Scripture theologian” or Grundtvigian) or Reformed etc. So it is seen: how the objective object of faith is depends on faith, on the subjective. And if one then starts from *faith*: how, then, can “a cognition that is as subjective, as inward, as absolutely personal as a true cognition of faith must necessarily be, be converted into the objective, impersonal form of science and still be cognition of faith?” On this the Dogmatics gave no enlightenment. Since, then, the “Christian Dogmatics” has *neither* set up and upheld a distinctive theological principle of cognition, independent of philosophy, *nor* acknowledged and carried through the principle of objective thinking, *nor* resolutely and without half-measures placed itself under the banner of faith, or at least presented the principle of faith pure and simple — the critique ends with the thesis: the “Christian Dogmatics” is without principle¹⁾.

The second author who came forward with a critique of Martensen’s dogmatics sets [28] out in his treatise¹⁾ two different relations between knowledge and faith. The first is: »*qværo intelligere ut credam*«. Here, then, faith is not the presupposition. The spirit that strives after cognition wanders with its intellectual love through the various spheres of objectivity, and does not suspect, “in the zeal of the process of cognition and in the first working days of the theoretically reflecting spirit”, that in the religious sphere it is situated otherwise than in the other spheres. “In the religious sphere, too, the Hegelian determination of truth as process, synthesis of the subjective and the objective, holds good, to be sure But — note well, and not to be forgotten — *in such a way* that the objective in this sphere is subjectivized, appropriated and made inward only in faith and hope, and by no means in a speculative-theoretical process”. It soon comes to light, therefore, that *pro* and *contra* here stand against each other — that there are “two

¹⁾What the critic’s verdict was when he disregarded the principle, and it was merely “a matter of judging this voluminous work solely with regard to the author’s talent, learning and gift of presentation”: see the “undersøgende Anmeldelse” p. 42–44.

^{1*)}Om den indbildte Forsoning af Tro og — Viden, med særligt Hensyn til Prof. Martensens ‘christelige Dogmatik.’ Af Mag. P. M. Stilling. 1850.

ways and no certainty beforehand". But before subjectivity resolves to seize the only certainty that can be in question here, that of faith and hope, serious theoretical and practical struggles will perhaps take place. "And least of all could one who reflects, of 'those valiant ranks', hit upon letting his power of thought be engaged as the yes-man of the dogmas; an engagement that is, to be sure, sometimes offered it by dogmatizing thinkers". — The proposition that the process of subjectivization in the religious sphere is qualitatively different from the theoretical one "is forgotten in greater or lesser degree in Hegel, Marheineke, in short in all speculative theologians. It is of no use at all that Prof. Martensen says: 'A *believer* can appropriate the Christian in a speculative-theoretical process.' That is fundamentally false". To show this the author passes on to the second standpoint: »*credo ut intelligam*«. This is "reflection *post fidem* (i.e., after I have taken the side of faith)". But — says the critic — "things go no better at all with reflection *post fidem* than *ante fidem* (i.e., before I took the side of faith and was still stuck right in the middle of the oppositions of reflection). The opposition of reflection (unbelief) was overcome in the first step of faith, not by reflection, but by and in believing living, which dictated obedience . . . And every following step (2. 3. 4 . . .) is of the same qualitative nature as the *first* step, which is continually repeated in the further course of the one who believes and hopes. And there may indeed be talk, and there is talk in Scripture too, of progress and growth in faith and hope, namely in the infinite strength of the subjective, personal certainty. But there is surely no talk of 'growing beyond' in growth, or in 'progress' going beyond the qualitative limits of the certainty of faith and hope to the *objective* certainty of proof"¹⁾. Since, however, the "Christian Dogmatics" had set up precisely such a »*credo ut intelligam*« as its principle, the critic asks: "Has Prof. Martensen really succeeded in lifting the cross of thought and in obtaining from the power of reflection its sincere support and sanction of the dogma?" And the result at which the critic then arrives, after an examination of the Dogmatics' treatment of the most important dogmas, is "that »*contra*« has not been vanquished at all, but only ignored or hushed up; that the testimony of reflection has been heard only with partiality, and is never allowed to have its full say", "that our dogmatician's »*credo*« is in practice only a scholastically inhibiting *credo*, which places the freedom of reflection under censorship and permits it no utterances other than such as are well-pleasing to the dogmatician's ear" (p. 66). — And the critic finds something teleological in the fact that »*contra*« cannot be scientifically set aside. For if there were a "proof *post fidem*", this [39] would have an unfortunate retroactive effect on the certainty of faith and hope. "For it is

¹⁾Op. cit. p. 37 f.

psychologically impossible, indeed only a pompous phrase, that I should at once have the certainty of faith and hope “independently of speculation,” “by an entirely different way than speculation,” and yet in the same breath, precisely by the ways of speculation, get the certainty of faith and hope more and more (the boundary grows fluid . . .) confirmed” (p. 64 note).

It cannot be denied that the critique had stated clearly and definitely what the point at issue was. What the objections were directed against was not this or that particular, but the dogmatic principle itself. The demand therefore necessarily had to be made of the anti-critique, if one should appear, that it should not — dogmatically — regard the dogmatic principle as standing unshakably firm, but should enter upon a closer grounding of it, and should develop clearly and unequivocally its relation to “pure” knowledge on the one side, and to faith on the other.

But the answer¹⁾ that the author of the Dogmatics gave his critics was now precisely a purely dogmatic one. It is indeed “an old experience that dogmatics always has critique in its train,” and “especially in our time, which is far more critical than dogmatic”; but as regards the critique of the present Dogmatics, the author thinks that it “cannot yet be said to have begun” (p. 7). This might seem strange to one who has read the two critical treatises mentioned above; but on closer examination one discovers that the critique is rejected because it attacks the principle itself: when it does that, then from the dogmatic standpoint it is not “proper” critique, indeed is really not noticed at all by dogmatics. Thus it takes up its position, e.g., toward Strauß, and toward any “thoroughgoing doubt about the foundation of Christianity”; however “significant” such a doubt may otherwise [31] be in other respects: it does not concern dogmatics at all! And why not? Because “the dogmatic interest” does not exist at all for such a doubter!¹⁾

Here, then, a secure barrier has been set against all critique. There could thus be no question of any real exchange between dogmatics and critique. Otherwise, however, the “dogmatic elucidation” varies in character.

Toward Mag. Stilling, e.g., the “dogmatic” showed itself in this, that “Mr. Magister’s scribbling” was at once “laid aside, not to be taken up again” (p. 8). Mag. Stilling rightly remarked on this in a later treatise: “Of the invincible and most honorable weapons with which a speculative dogmatician is able to maintain his standpoint against thoroughly argued attacks from the side of former friends, Prof. Martensen’s anathema upon my critique affords a very instructive example.”

The weightiest critique of the Dogmatics had already been written before it appeared:

¹⁾“Dogmatische Oplysninger”. An occasional piece by Dr. H. Martensen. 1850.

¹⁾See Martensen’s Dogmatics § 31 note.

by the pseudonyms. Nevertheless, in the Dogmatics itself no regard at all was paid to these authors, except that in the preface “some among us” are reproached for wanting to be “absolute in faith”²⁾. Now Prof. Nielsen in his critique had brought Johannes Climacus forward again, so that what had been neglected might perhaps be made good. The “Dogmatiske Oplysninger” consequently had to elucidate the relation of the Dogmatics to the pseudonyms. Now although these authors are declared “wholly irrelevant in the [32] present connection,” although the author’s “acquaintance with this extensive literature is only very slight and fragmentary,” he nevertheless declares that he has an entirely different conception of these writings than the reviewer: namely, that they did not mean to “ground a reform of dogmatics” but “in Socratic fashion to set a deeper skepticism in motion, in order thereby to awaken the reader to seek the problem that is higher and more than all theological and philosophical school problems, namely the personal problem of life” (p. 12). And one need not have read much in the pseudonymous writings to confirm the truth of these words. But, in the first place, the author of the Dogmatics was not at all at odds with his reviewer here; for the latter had indeed precisely wanted to prevent his “conception of the book’s (i.e., the “Unscientific Postscript’s”) scientific significance from being confused with the author’s perhaps somewhat divergent¹⁾ main thought” (Prof. Nielsen’s “undersøgende Anmeldelse” p. 7). And secondly — must not the “science of faith” fall if Johannes Climacus’s concept of faith is correct? Unless, that is, one regards the “deeper skepticism” he wants to set in motion as so deep that it acquires no real significance. — For the rest, the “Dogmatiske Oplysninger” will have nothing to do with Joh. Climacus himself; he is dismissed as irrelevant; but only with Prof. Nielsen’s presentation of his — “theses.” It is then declared that “what is new in them is not true, what is true not new”; thereupon a number of old truths are discussed — without any inquiry into whether the new might not lie precisely in the manner in which they were set forth²⁾; until the author stops at two “new theses” in order to prove that they are not truths. The first of these, “the truth, inwardness and subjectivity,” was new to the [33] author “in the sense that he had not found it in any dogmatics known to him” (p. 16). This was not so strange after all, since the thesis (at least in its secondary thought, its consequence) is polemical against scientific dogmatics. The other thesis that was new to

²⁾As one easily sees, an ambiguous expression: for it is one thing to maintain the principle of faith absolutely, without abating it, and another to declare oneself to stand at the absolute height of faith. — For the rest, the preface also alluded to “a few individuals who, without feeling any urge toward coherent thinking, can satisfy themselves by thinking in stray thoughts and aphorisms, notions and flashes.” Thus ran the verdict in 1849. Would it also run thus in 1866?

¹⁾With this may be compared the relation, so characteristic of Kierkegaard, in which he placed himself to this polemic. See “Kierkegaards Bladartikler” p. 252 note.

^{2*)}Objectively the accent falls on: *what* is said; subjectively: *how* it is said.” Unscient. Postscr. p. 149.

the author was: “for the existing subjectivity the highest truth is the paradox.” In this thesis the author rightly thought that “the problem was to be found”; but unfortunately he forgot that in order to recognize that the truth, the highest truth, is the paradox, one must necessarily proceed from the standpoint of the *existing* subjectivity: what wonder, then, that his objective-dogmatic investigation arrives at the result that “paradoxical” is only a rhetorical hyperbole, and the paradox something invented by the serpent in Paradise (p. 23)!

If one asks what the “Dogmatiske Oplysninger” teach about the relation between existential and scientific cognition, there are two points in particular to which we may draw attention. In order to show that faith contains within itself a germ of science, the author insists that faith is not merely “consciousness of redemption” but “consciousness of revelation” (p. 30–40). Failure to heed this is supposed to be the basic error in Johannes Climacus’s concept of faith, as set forth by Prof. Nielsen. But what in the world does this elucidation help? Does faith become more scientific because it is consciousness of revelation? Or is not revelation precisely true only for the *believer*, and only *insofar as* he is a believer? Is it a *scientific* striving “to seek revelation in redemption,” “by the way of devotion and believing contemplation to seek to know the God who through his work of redemption discloses his essence to our gaze”? But let us nevertheless assume for a moment that dogmatics succeeds in getting started on its task: “scientifically to develop the contemplative moment of faith,” — of what kind, then, will the scientific cognition be that results from it? Here the author maintains — and this is the second [34] point we wish to bring forward — that “dogmatic inquiry into and searching of the truths of revelation” is not “a variety or a corruption of philosophical speculation,” but has “its own principle, independent of philosophy, and should therefore also be judged by its own standard” (p. 66–68); for “the redemption of fallen human nature” must also embrace the redemption of thought, as surely as it is “the purpose of Christianity to restore true humanity completely” (p. 22).

There is thus a specifically theological-scientific principle of cognition — which is to be “nothing other than what lies in the rightly understood doctrine of the *testimonium spiritus sancti*” (Dogmatics § 29). This is precisely a crux of the whole dispute. Prof. Nielsen had already directed his attention to it in the “undersøgende Anmeldelse”; in the “Illumination” of the “Dogmatiske Oplysninger” with which he concluded the polemic¹⁾, it is said with regard to the aforementioned “theoretical significance of the *testimonium spiritus sancti*”: “According to Dr. Martensen’s “basic view,” then, there are to be two kinds

¹⁾ Dr. H. Martensens “Dogmatiske Oplysninger” belyste af Prof. R. Nielsen”. 1850.

of objective cognition, namely: a lower, worldly, general-scientific one, which cannot yet say: *Credo ut intelligam*, since it is still in its sinfulness, . . . and a higher, ecclesiastical, dogmatic-scientific cognition, which can straightway say: *Credo ut intelligam*, since it is redeemed by the grace of God, and so redeemed that it can produce the genuine theological speculation In the speculative pulpit style, which preaches speculation without thinking the thought, such an assurance about “the redemption of thought” may certainly look quite good, both upbuilding and speculative; but — “show me thy faith by thy²⁾ works!” ” (p. 37–38).

[35] For one must ask: does one have a different logic and ontology on the dogmatic standpoint (i.e., after having been regenerated) than otherwise in science? Now since it is clear that theology in this respect is subject to the same conditions as the universally human sciences, where then is this logic and ontology to be checked? Surely in philosophy, which “by its logical and ontological investigations forms a propaedeutic foundation for all science” (Martensen’s Dogmatics § 36)? But how then can the “non-believing,” “non-regenerate” science check the “believing” and “regenerate”? And what other outcome will this checking have than that the “*believing* science” must be assigned “a place of its own *outside* science”? And if one then wished to answer this by citing 1 Cor. 2, 14–15, that would at once be a confirmation that this verdict was right, and a great misunderstanding of what “the Spirit of God” means.

A principle, to be sure, is not to seek its grounding outside itself, but to be something self-valid. But a scientific principle must be able to give a scientific account of itself. It is of no use, when the checking comes too close, then to appeal to faith and declare that on the basis of it one has a higher scientific standing.

And herewith, then, we conclude our account of this polemic. It has often been said that such literary polemics are unfruitful and without result. And certainly it may be difficult to state in a finite sense the result at which one has arrived. But by every able polemic this at least is achieved, that the contending principles get a hearing and step forth onto the field of battle to venture a joust with one another. And will it not then soon become manifest who, ideally regarded, is the vanquished? When objections have been raised that strike the matter in its innermost essence, and one then simply dismisses them without properly engaging with them, is that not a defeat?

[36] And precisely in this manner did dogmatics, in the polemic treated here, conduct itself toward critique. That I think I have shown by the foregoing account. If one wishes to call it partisan and one-sided, I answer: show me another way of understanding the

²⁾Cf. Grundideernes Logik I, p. 44–53, where it is shown in a single example how little the deed here answers to the faith.

matter; show that dogmatics has really engaged with critique and overcome it! show that dogmatics has been able to appear with a good conscience before the tribunal of science as well as before that of faith, that it has been able to unite both without halving them and abating both!

The three combatants who earlier stood on the field of battle against one another have thus been reduced to two. But this duel gives occasion to several misgivings. On the one side stands faith, on the other side — well, what really stands there now? Strauß asserts the modern consciousness and its world-view in opposition to the standpoint of “the old, especially oriental world,” from which the biblical writings were composed. “The modern age has a series of laborious investigations, continued through centuries, to thank for the insight that everything in the world hangs together by a chain of causes and effects that tolerates no interruption From this standpoint the biblical narratives cannot possibly appear as history The divine cannot have happened thus; what happened thus cannot have been divine.” How, then, does the modern, scientific consciousness here take its position toward Christianity? Well, it takes seriously that the researcher of religion is to relate himself to revelation as the natural scientist to nature: namely, in such a way that he seeks in a rational, scientific manner the laws that lie at the ground. This standpoint Hegel had approved with respect to mythology¹⁾; it was Feuerbach who with great acuteness carried this further and sought to find the psychological laws that [37] had guided the origin and development of religion, and especially of Christianity¹⁾. Thus he came to the thesis: “Religion ist das bewußtlose Selbstbewußtsein des Menschen” (p. 37). Before human self-consciousness is properly developed, it cannot intuit its own universal essence, the idea as idea, but clothes it in a form of fantasy, personifies it, and endows the personal God thus arisen with human attributes. Religion has thus arisen through one’s having made subject what should be predicate, and vice versa; thereby the illusion of an opposition between the divine and the human has arisen. “Gott ist der Begriff der Gattung als Individuum” (p. 202). “Das Bewußtsein des Menschen in seiner Totalität ist das Bewußtsein der Trinität” (p. 72). Theology, therefore, is anthropology. What must now be done, now that reason and self-consciousness have come of age, is: to make what for religion is the main thing, the subject, into the subordinate thing, the predicate. “Das Richtige, Wahre und Gute hat überall seinen Heiligungsgrund in sich

¹⁾“Die Hauptsache der Mythologie ist das Werk der phantasirenden Vernunft, die sich das Wesen zum Gegenstande macht, aber noch kein andres Organ hat als die sinnliche Vorstellungsweise; daher die Götter als Menschen erscheinen. Die Mythologie kann nun studirt werden für die Kunst u. s. w.; der denkende Geist muß aber den substantiellen Inhalt, den Gedanken, das Philosophem, das implicite darin inthalten ist, aufsuchen, *wie man in der Natur Vernunft sucht*”. Geschichte der Philosophie. I, p. 98.

¹⁾“Das Wesen des Christenthums”. Von Ludwig Feuerbach. Leipzig. 1841.

selbst, in seiner Qualität. Wo es Ernst mit der Ethik ist, da gilt sie eben an und für sich selbst für eine göttliche Macht" (p. 375 f.).

Strauß and Feuerbach say that they speak in the name of science. But can they now also really count as the rightful representatives of science over against religion? or must it not be said to be a one-sided conception of scientific reflection that it should testify [38] only *contra*, just as it is one-sided when theology can hear only the testimony *pro*? And finally, would it not be a precarious relation in which science came to stand to humanity and the spiritual life, if over against religion it had to be absolutely destructive?

How the matter stands from the side of faith: that faith has its own sphere, where it does not acknowledge the supremacy of science (and were it once to engage with objective reflection, it would be in a bad way: for here there are, after all, both *pro* and *contra*, two ways!), — this we have already seen in the foregoing. It is S. Kierkegaard who has fought for this, the religious side of the matter.

But science, philosophy, too, must of course become clear with itself about what its right relation to religion is. From this side Prof. R. Nielsen has worked on the problems belonging here. And it is clear that the settling of this point must be brought about by the scientific route.

The first question, then, is: why do the results of science always sound *contra* revelation for Strauß and Feuerbach? Presumably for the same reason by which theology always hears a *pro* from the mouth of science: the freethinker's science is an unbelieving science, theology a believing science. But faith and unbelief are not scientific principles: they belong to life, to existence.

Science asks only about the definite, objective grounds. "From the standpoint of life, on the other hand, subjectivity reigns"; here, then, everything is decided by subjective grounds. Now when, therefore, a decision of questions that belong to the sphere of existence, of the personal and religious life, gives itself out to be scientific, it is clear that the two domains are confused, — whether the decision then falls out in the one direction or the other. "The Straußian endeavor to raise science to religion cannot possibly be heterogeneous with the theological endeavor to raise religion to science; for [39] both endeavors proceed, after all, from the presupposition that religion and science are homogeneous" (Evangelietroen og Theologien p. 82).

There is, then, nothing else for science to do but to pronounce its *non liquet* concerning these questions and to leave their decision to the sphere where they belong. It becomes merely comical when it comes forward here with its objective reasons and fills the scales, the one with *pros*, the other with *contras* — and behold! after all it does not depend in

the least on these reasons to which side the scale sinks.

“But,” Strauß will say, “everything in the world is, after all, connected by a chain of causes and effects; the miracle must therefore be rejected by science as a sheer impossibility.” To this the answer from the side of philosophy is that this must certainly seem so to the physicist; for “the causes of physics are causes of things, its laws are laws of necessity; but the highest cause of philosophy is an idea-cause, and the idea-cause a teleological self-cause. Inasmuch as the absolute self-cause lays the laws of necessity at the foundation of the law of freedom, there is seen from the height of idea-cognition a depth of possibilities which no human knowledge is able to measure out. Instead of fantasizing about the indeterminable and brooding over the unfathomable, philosophy here holds fast to the essential task: to secure the right of science by stating the limit of knowledge”¹⁾. Philosophy, then, could not possibly assert the validity of spirit and of the ideal in existence if it were to *break* with religion, where the absolute omnipotence of spirit is asserted. If this holds in the intellectual domain, then it holds even more in the ethical. For it is not the case, as Feuerbach thinks, that “das Richtige, Wahre und Gute” would be able to hold its own in actual life if it were not supported by religion. The idea of the good would soon be eliminated by human reflection¹⁾. As surely, therefore, [40] as philosophy is to have an ethics, where “the thoughts of life meet with the scientific fundamental thoughts,” so surely is it true that it dare not declare the Gospel to be a myth (Grundideernes Logik XXVII).

But philosophy can just as little comprehend and ground the Gospel. “In declaring that objectivity is the truth, science by that very act renounces all influence on faith.”

This does not, however, exclude that religion and personal life in general can become an object of science. But this can then only happen in such a way that the subjective is “objectified in reflection,” and the religious view is thus had “at second hand,” “not in a religious way,” but “through the medium of thought and imagination” (cf. Martensen’s Dogmatics § 8, note). Here one must then hold fast to the categorical “difference between the scientific in the wider and in the narrower sense” (R. Nielsen’s philos. Propædeutik p. 78). Scientific only in the wider sense is every treatment of an object that lies outside the sphere where science rules with absolute *dominium*; hence every presentation of the subjective, personal life. What is scientific lies in the objective treatment. Such a “science of subjectivity” can then have the religious truths as its object, not in order to ground them, but in order to “illuminate them as many-sidedly as possible,” in that it “conceives the ideals of faith as ideals of life and finds in the end aimed at the standard

¹⁾Grundideernes Logik. I, p. XXIV.

¹⁾This is developed in detail in “Forelæsninger over philos. Propædeutik 1860–61”. p. 416–423.

for judging the means" (Grundideernes Logik XXVI).

Now if it is the case that there is a qualitative difference between faith and knowledge, that they belong to entirely different spheres, then the possibility of their reconciliation [41] is thereby given. Where, in what domain, in what sphere is this reconciliation to take place? In the sphere of knowledge? But then knowledge itself is both party and judge; the mediation will therefore be partial, the unity one-sided (cf. Unscient. Postscr. p. 286 f.). In the sphere of faith? Here the answer can be Yes, if by "the sphere of faith" one understands the sphere of personal existing as a whole. It is the existing subjectivity that has a relation both to knowledge and to faith, in whose consciousness the conflict is waged. "The conflict is psychological; it is human frailty, which has neither resignation enough to reconcile itself with what is objective in science, nor inwardness enough to hold fast to faith" (Philos. Propæd. p. 77).

If the heterogeneity between faith and knowledge were not absolute but only relative, so that both belonged to the same sphere, how would they then be able to be united in one consciousness without contradiction? When faith says one thing and science something entirely other and opposite, how would one then be able to reconcile these conflicting assertions? If, on the other hand, it is recognized that one thing is existential and religious truth, another scientific truth, then the rule can hold: »*Suum cuique!*« Then it is clear that the psychological reconciliation *can* (for whether it *actually* comes about depends, after all, on the single existing subjectivity) take place, namely in such a way that faith is set highest, while science is nevertheless retained as a relative task; for the reverse is not possible¹⁾.

The reconciliation between faith and knowledge, then, is not settled dogmatically in the Nielsenian philosophy. On the contrary, everyone receives a direction and a summons to accomplish the reconciliation practically and ethically in the course of his own personal development of life. What philosophy can teach us is to hold the principles [42] fast, not to distort and confound them. If it should then seem as though the conflict could not be settled, as though the struggle never came to an end — then Ørsted's words hold: "Let us give truth the honor! With it the good is indissolubly bound up. The full truth brings its own comfort with it." And the comfort is this, that one has not denied the ideal.

It must also be remembered here that science is only a single side, albeit an exceedingly significant one, of human life. If the question, therefore, is the relation between

¹⁾Thus it is precisely *because* faith and knowledge are absolutely heterogeneous that their psychological reconciliation is possible. It is a great misunderstanding to put, instead of this "because," a "*though*" (see Mr. cand. mag. Brandes's article in "Fædrelandet" of January 13th). Then one can easily find "obscurities"!

Christianity and science, this is only a particular form of the question of the relation between Christianity and humanity as a whole. Science stands beside art, family life and civic life, in short: everything that belongs to the purely human, the relative over against what in Christianity is set up as the highest end: "the Kingdom of God."

In these other directions, too, a confounding of the Christian and the humane is possible; indeed it has taken place, and it surely takes place still. Here, too, the point is not to be finished with the "reconciliation" too early, but to fix the oppositions in view as sharply as possible — and then to take one's side.

In Holy Scripture one finds no direct information about the relation between faith and knowledge, between Christianity and humanity. This has its ground in the fact that Christ and the apostles stood at such a height of existence, so absolutely at the religious standpoint, that the — in relation to this, relative — realm of humane ideas became something altogether vanishing. But this holds only for one who stands at the standpoint of inspiration, where the Holy Spirit works unconditionally and immediately, without engaging with and entering into interaction with the given conditions (cf. Acts of the Apostles 2, 3–4).

In the time that followed, human culture developed in interaction with, indeed for a long time under the guardianship of, religion. But the consciousness of an opposition [43] between the two keeps coming back. If the opposition now becomes a dualism, then only two ways are possible: the ascetic's or the freethinker's. The one breaks with humanity, the other with Christianity.

But let us look more closely: is the ascetic's standpoint that of the faith of the Gospel, of original Christianity? One need not have read much in the New Testament to know that a violent and painful break between Christianity and humanity, such as the one we find in the ascetic's life, is not found in the apostle. He unites, in the power and loftiness of the spirit, the decisive oppositions, without one noticing any pain, any restless unclarity in him; whereas the ascetic writhes as under a heavy burden.

Thus: "Respect for the monastic movement of the Middle Ages!" (Joh. Climacus) Respect for one who can bear the unconditioned unconditionally in this world of conditions! But the ascetic exemplar dare not obscure the evangelical one. The Gospel has laid an interdict neither on science nor on the state nor on any universally human condition.

From this it is concluded that it must be possible to unite the Christian and the humane, that a dualism cannot possibly be the right relation.

If Christianity really still exists, if it has not been overcome by advancing culture, then it must be possible to hold fast to the evangelical ideal in the midst of the humane

world. But it is just as certain that one must then acknowledge that one lives under other spiritual conditions than the apostolic and New Testament ones.

For above all: no confounding. And a confounding takes place where one does not heed the essential and decisive opposition. Then one gets neither true Christianity nor true humanity. —

If the reconciliation of faith and knowledge is to be psychological, existential, then [44] it can be seen how little to the point the objection is that by referring faith and knowledge to qualitatively different spheres one secures one's standpoint of faith against all freethinkers' objections: "what risk is there in believing 'against the concept' when we have secured for ourselves in advance the insight that the concept has no validity whatever in the sphere of faith?" ("Dogmatiske Oplysninger" p. 74). For because it is recognized *scientifically* that knowledge has no authority in the domain of faith, does it thereby become easier to *believe*? On the contrary, the insight that has here been won in *knowledge* must be won again from the very beginning and on other terms when it is a matter of *believing*. For "it cannot be set up as a new dogma about dogma that dogma is a crux for thought. Only in the attempt to lift dogma does the power of reflection make this discovery"¹⁾. And as regards the talk of "the simple believers who without such a preparation take their stand at the standpoint of faith," it must be remarked, first: that it is, as has been said, a misunderstanding when there is talk of "such a preparation," and next: that here the same "simple" difference holds between "the wise man" and "the simple man" as in all ethical cognition: "the simple man knows it; the wise man knows that he knows it" (Joh. Climacus). For the rest, it is hardly from the side of speculative theology that there should be too much talk of "the simple believers."

While here one has sought to present the view of a difference of spheres between faith and knowledge as a new "scholasticism," there are others who accuse it of scientific "skepticism." It "strikes" Mr. Larsen (in "Dagbladet" of January 19th)²⁾, he "can in no [45] way get it into his head," how one can get a science that recognizes "eternal laws of nature" without directly declaring the miracle impossible. He then states "three possible standpoints" toward the miracle, but to little use for the reader; for one is not told whether all three of these standpoints are scientific, or whether one or two of them are, or whether perhaps none at all of them is. And yet it was on this that the whole matter depended. On this he should have consulted his "expert building commission." From the same quarter he might perhaps also find out for me what "strikes" me, what I "cannot

¹⁾Stilling: "Om den indbildte Forsoning af Tro og — Viden". p. 55 note.

²⁾From this article one sees, moreover, that if Mr. Larsen has learned nothing else from the earlier conflict over this matter, he has at least learned to pronounce the ban.

get into my head,” namely: how does one go about drawing the miracle into science and alongside this holding on to natural science with its “eternal laws of nature”?

The same question that is treated so clumsily here comes forward in a far clearer way in Mr. G. Brandes’s articles in “Fædrelandet” of January 13th and 20th. I understand the question thus: how can philosophy, in its own domain, scientifically justify the regard it pays to a sphere foreign to it? — With this the discussion is led away from the boundary dispute between philosophy and theology to the purely philosophical domain¹⁾. To that extent it does not properly concern the present treatise. Nevertheless I will remark the following.

What is demanded can only be the explicit development of what it means that “the highest cause of philosophy” is “the absolute self-cause” (*Grundideernes Logik* XXIV). This development can, in Mr. Brandes’s opinion, take place only in the transition from the circle of knowledge to that of power and, in a still more concrete form, in the transition [46] from logic to the philosophy of nature. But if Mr. Brandes really has found no elements at all for the solution of his problem in what has so far appeared of “*Grundideernes Logik*,” then he should not have confined himself to wishing for elucidation and completion, but then he would have had to find fault already in the development of “*Subjectivitets Logik*” and “*Functionernes Logik*.” For that lack necessarily presupposes this fault, if indeed what has appeared of “*Grundideernes Logik*” really is a whole in itself and not a fragment.

Besides, it surprises me that Mr. Brandes has not taken account of the significance that is ascribed to ethics in the introduction to “*Grundideernes Logik*” (p. XXVII). For if there is to be a philosophical ethics, then it cannot stand in contradiction with logic and the philosophy of nature. And since ethics forms a transition between philosophy and religion, the way is thereby shown by which one, without “making science religious” or “writing a new theology,” can respect the religious by recognizing the limit of science. —

Here there may be much still to do. Nor has it been promised that all questions shall be able to find their absolute solution. “It is not the case with the progress of our knowledge that the remaining problems should become fewer, easier and more insignificant the nearer we approach the ideal; on the contrary! the more clearly the ideal is seen, the higher the problems become and the deeper runs the stream of inquiries”¹⁾. — But what

¹⁾Mr. Brandes stands in a peculiar relation to Mr. Larsen. At first glance one would think that he was defending Mr. Larsen; but then he declares the latter’s defense of theology to be insignificant and ascribes merit to him only as an attacker; and behold, then the point where Mr. Brandes thinks the attack must be made is an entirely different one from the one Mr. L. has attacked. Consequently Mr. L. retains only the merit of having attacked Prof. Nielsen at all.

¹⁾*Grundideernes Logik* p. 253.

can be attained is that essential progress is made, that one comes to be placed more rightly. And herein lies, in my conviction, the great significance of the view in the philosophy of religion presented here, whose historical presuppositions, development and essential content I have endeavored to make clear in this little treatise.
